Rehabilitation Plan After Lumbosacral Fusion

1. Morning Routine

Before rising, on your back, knees bent: 10 slow belly breaths, 20 ankle pumps, 10 gentle knee rocks, 10 small pain-free pelvic tilts. Then roll sideways as one unit and push up with your arms.

Backward leaning: avoid it for the first hour. After a warm shower, lean back with hands on hips, small range, 5 times, stopping before sharp pain. Still painful? Skip it and ask your physiotherapist.

2. Sleep

- Side lying: long pillow between knees and ankles, rolled towel under your waist, neck level.
- Alternative: on your back, pillow under knees.
- Woken by pain: roll as one unit, breathe slowly, use heat; if awake over 20 minutes, get up briefly.
- Log waking times for your pain doctor.

3. Twelve-Week Progression

- **Weeks 1–4:** Daily program 1–2 rounds of 15 repetitions. Hard program twice weekly, 1–2 rounds; skip exercises 9 and 12 (backward bending) until your physiotherapist approves.
- **Weeks 5–8:** Daily program 2–3 rounds. Hard program every other day, 2–3 rounds. Add listed progressions gradually.
- **Weeks 9–12:** Hard program 3 rounds to fatigue. Daily program 1–2 rounds on rest days. Build up walking.

Flare-up rules:

- Exercise pain should settle within a day.
- Worse next morning? Drop back one stage for 3 days.
- Flare-up: keep walking, halve the daily program, pause the hard program until 2 good days.

4. Questions for Your Team

Physiotherapist:

- How far may I lean backward, and when?
- Should any exercise be modified for my fusion?

Pain doctor (medication review):

- Is Malfin right long term, or could it increase pain sensitivity?
- Does medication wearing off cause night waking?
- Does amitriptyline cause morning stiffness?
- Is low-dose naltrexone suitable, can it combine with Malfin, and how would a switch be managed safely?

Surgeon:

- Does imaging confirm the fusion is solid?
- Could backward-leaning pain come from the hardware or the level above?

5. Other Suggestions

- Pain psychology, or cognitive behavioural therapy for insomnia.
- Warm-water pool training.
- A pain and sleep diary.
- No smoking; it slows fusion healing.

Warning Signs: Seek Urgent Care

Call 112 or 1813 for:

- Groin or buttock numbness, or loss of bladder or bowel control.
- New or worsening leg weakness or numbness.
- Fever with back pain, or a red or leaking scar.
- Sudden severe, unusual pain.
- Excessive drowsiness or slow breathing.